

THE HEAVENS GATES CHRONICLES

BLOOD FREQUENCY



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Book Three of the Heavens Gates Chronicles

By Robert Leon Geter II

A novel of bloodline, music, spiritual war, and the opening of a deeper conflict.

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*Dedicated to those who carried old memory in silence until the time
came to name it.*

*To those who learned that blood can hold burden, debt, destiny, and
instruction all at once.*

*And to those who build under pressure without forgetting what gave
them life.*

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Opening Note

Book One was the declaration.

Book Two was the proof.

Book Three is where the deeper law comes forward.

Not all at once. Not in full daylight. But enough to make plain that Barry Parker was never building from ambition alone. There was blood in it. Burden in it. Spirit in it. And there were older forces, older memories, and older enemies moving beneath the music long before the city had language for any of it.

This is the book where the machine answers.

This is also the book where the blood begins answering back.

Chapter One - Of the Visit, the Book, and the Bloodline

The prison had a way of flattening life into sequence.

Wake. Count. Noise. Rules. Food. Watching. Waiting. Men trying not to become the walls and men who already had. The state liked it that way. It preferred repetition because repetition shaved difference off the soul. A boy entered with a particular face, a particular rhythm, a particular idea of himself. Enough repetition and the place would try to sand all that down into something easier to manage.

Barry Parker learned that early.

His mother came when she could, twice a year if life and money aligned right. He loved her enough not to turn the visits into fantasy. Prison punished men who expected too much tenderness from a room built to interrupt tenderness for sport. Still, the day JoAnn Parker arrived with the book, Barry knew before she sat down that this would not be ordinary.

She carried certainty.

Not performance. Not church-lady frenzy. Not grief made dramatic.

For a few minutes they talked the old way. Family names. Small news. Familiar concern. Enough rhythm to honor all the visits before. Then JoAnn looked at him so long the room around them seemed to step backward.

"You not no ordinary Black boy from no ordinary blood."

The sentence hit harder than shouting would have. She pulled a cloth-wrapped book from her bag, old in the way things get old when they have been protected on purpose.

"Your daddy told me to give you this when you was ready."

Barry stared at the book, then at her.

"What you mean ready?"

"He said I would know. When the time come when nothing can save you but yourself once you acknowledge and accept what you are."

He wanted to joke it off. Couldn't.

"What is this, Ma?"

"The best of times," she said.

That irritated him because it sounded too large for that room.

"Talk plain."

She did.

"Your father wasn't dead the way they told it."

Something in Barry went still.

All his life there had been something crooked about the story of Solomon Gray's disappearance. No body. No clean ending. Just enough silence to keep a child suspicious and not enough truth to settle anything.

"He human," JoAnn said before his mind could run wild. "This ain't no sci-fi mess. He a man. Flesh and blood. But your daddy had what they call blood memory. Ancient bloodline awakened. And once that wake in a person, they don't belong to ordinary life the same."

Barry looked at her hard.

"Why ain't you never tell me?"

"It ain't something I can just tell you because you ask," she said. "You got to be in transition. Timing got to present itself. Never move ahead of destiny. Nothing real live outside your destiny, and if you give root to something outside it, you be chasing ghosts."

Then she named the debt.

"You planted root in the wrong thing. You took that boy property. Then you took that other boy life. The Great Mother was divinated and what came back was clear. You violated what was sacred and broke the path of a soul you didn't create. You owe a bloodline. You owe a lineage. A whole branch that won't see itself move through this life the way it was supposed to because you canceled it."

Prison had punished him already.

This felt deeper than punishment.

This felt like accounting.

"That don't make you lesser than," she said. "But the burden on your soul now is real. Your life in this world at the disposal of the bloodline. May the Great Mother and the ancestors have mercy on your soul."

The room held still.

He touched the book.

"What's in it?"

JoAnn looked at him with the kind of tenderness only truth can carry after it has already wounded.

"What's already in you."

After that, somehow, they had a more ordinary visit. That part would haunt him too. The way revelation can sit down at a table, rearrange a life, and then make room again for family talk as if both things belong to the same hour.

Back in his cell, Barry unwrapped the book and did not read it right away. He only held it. Felt the years in it. Felt his father's timing in it. Felt how small the bunk was under a question that large.

Then he opened it.

And from that moment on, the prison no longer held only his punishment.

It held his first doorway.

Chapter Two - Of Detroit, Makaila, and the Second Becoming

Barry got out at twenty-one and stayed in Detroit twelve years.

That mattered.

Later, when Columbia tried to explain the Barry Parker it met, people would want to compress too much. They would want one stain, one prison term, one dramatic return, and call that enough. But men like Barry are not made in one wound. They are made in the years after the wound, when life stops reacting to what happened and starts testing what kind of man came out of it.

Detroit held him through that test.

He worked.

Barry didn't come out talking empire before he had learned rhythm. He worked jobs that taught timing, people, weather, maintenance, and the mathematics of showing up. Over time he built a lawn and home-care company doing real numbers. Not fantasy wealth. Working wealth. The kind that teaches a man that consistency outruns performance every time.

By his early thirties he had two children, a seven-year-old son and a six-year-old daughter, and fatherhood had done what prison and revelation alone could not fully do. It stripped some of the theater out of ambition. Children make a man understand that building has to survive mood.

By then he was sharing a three-bedroom house in Romulus near the airport with Makaila.

It was the kind of house that told one story from the street and another one inside. Nice mixed neighborhood. Maintained yard. Two attractive Black professionals moving with a thoughtfulness that gave off married-with-children energy whether papers had caught up or not. The children loved the rhythm of it. The adults respected the restraint of it.

Makaila had already changed the house too.

The basement had once been wasted possibility. Barry renovated it under her direction into a plush studio apartment - enough privacy to feel like its own home, enough integration to remain part of the body. Two homes for the price of one and a half. That was how her mind worked. She looked at numbers, square footage, debt, business structure, and hidden value the way some people looked at clouds.

They had not rushed sex.

That mattered too.

A little flirting, yes. Some energy. Some glances. But no careless hunger, no childish grabbing at a future because the chemistry was obvious. That restraint gave the bond weight.

One early morning she caught him in ritual.

The house still belonged to first light. The children were barely awake. Barry was already moving through the sequence with that same serious calm he gave anything sacred. Makaila stood in the doorway watching longer than she meant to.

Later she asked the question.

"Why you never talk to me about your spiritual views?"

Barry looked over his cup and gave one of them slight sly smiles of his.

"Maybe because you never asked straight."

She narrowed her eyes.

"I'm asking now."

He set the cup down.

And the room changed.

Not into danger.

Into honesty.

Barry did not give her floating mysticism or borrowed grand language. He spoke plain first. Law. Balance. Truth. Destiny. The Great Mother and the masculine principle not as decoration but as living structure. He told her that discipline was not just work ethic - it was spiritual requirement. That illusion was giving root to what never truly belonged to you. That a person had to hold order in the self before they could hold anything else in righteousness.

Makaila listened harder than she let on.

Later that evening they were in the basement apartment with sage going and Tibetan bowls humming low in the background. Smoke drifted slow. The room had that warm half-dark that makes people either lie prettier or tell the truth more simply.

Makaila asked real questions.

How do balance and doctrine govern a household?

How do they govern business?

How do you know the difference between survival and path?

How do you lead without becoming hard in the wrong places?

Barry answered without performance.

And over the course of that conversation, something old and quiet between them moved into the open. Not loud. Not dramatic. Recognition.

The first kiss came there.

Not reckless. Not overdue in the cheap way. Like something already true finally stepping through the doorway made for it.

Afterward they did not cheapen it with too much talking. They sat there in the room they had made, while the bowls softened into silence and the smoke thinned around them.

The children took to the shift naturally. Makaila was already good with them. Good with their mother too, because Barry ran a tight ship that way. He did not allow adult complexity to spill disorder onto children just because grown people wanted to be sloppy.

That was part of his doctrine too.

And from that point on, whatever uncertainty remained between Barry and Makaila was no longer about whether the bond was real.

It was only about what destiny intended to do with it next.

Chapter Three - Of the Man Returned From Paper

By the time Slim Mac reappeared, Columbia had already learned how to talk in fragments before it ever learned how to tell the truth.

A rumor would come down one block like outrage, turn the corner and become admiration, hit another neighborhood and return wearing fear, then by nightfall settle into the bloodstream like everybody had known it from the start.

So when word spread that Slim Mac was back out, back walking, back breathing city air, the reaction came exactly like that.

Fragments first.

Then fever.

Then myth.

Some said it was a paperwork issue. Some said the case had been dirty from the beginning. Some said the narcotics contact's corruption poisoned the whole file. Some said luck. Some said God. Some said the devil. Some said, "That nigga always had people."

That last one was closer than they knew.

Barry heard before most because by now information moved toward him the way weather moves toward certain trees. He didn't have to chase everything. He had built enough structure that the important things came when they were supposed to.

He was up in one of the rooms at Sunset when the word reached him.

A runner stood in the doorway and said it clean.

"Slim out."

That was all.

No panic. No dressing.

The man from Florence in the room tried to talk too fast.

"How the hell-"

Barry raised one finger without fully turning.

Silence returned.

He stood, buttoned his jacket slowly, and went to the window overlooking the rear lot. Life below kept moving - boxes, cars, gear, security. Everything looked the same.

It wasn't.

"What else?" he asked.

The runner gave the rest. Appeal bond. Corrupt contact. Death. Weak paper. City already talking.

Barry nodded once.

Nothing more.

Anyone who didn't know him would've missed the seriousness of it. But the people who really understood Barry knew when he went quieter, the machinery in him had gotten louder.

The Florence man tried again.

"So what this mean?"

Barry turned this time, a crooked half-smile touching one side of his mouth.

"It mean luck don't move that clean."

That was the real answer.

Slim Mac did not belong to the class of men who simply stumbled back into freedom through grace. Not after everything that had happened. Not after the city had already watched his world crack.

No.

Something bigger had opened the corridor.

Barry didn't need all the proof yet.

He only needed pattern.

And pattern told him one thing plain:

the board had changed.

Again.

Chapter Four - Of the Public Lie and the Private Hand

By nightfall the city had already told the story a hundred wrong ways.

At barber shops it sounded like clerical stupidity.

On porches it sounded like dark justice.

In little back rooms it sounded like proof that Slim had always been protected.

Among younger fools, it had already started collecting myth.

That was the dangerous part.

Not just that he was back.

That he could return carrying narrative.

When Barry got home, Makaila was already at the dining table under one lamp, papers spread, one hand on a pen, her locks falling thick over one shoulder. She looked up once when he entered.

"It's him?"

Barry nodded.

Makaila leaned back.

"I knew the air felt wrong."

That brought the slightest trace of amusement through him.

"You think it's Daniel?" she asked.

Barry took his time.

"I think it's a hand like his. Whether direct or not, same class of move."

That was enough for now.

Naming too much too early was for emotional people. Barry and Makaila were beyond that. Intuition was guide. Structure was proof.

Publicly the story was simple enough to travel:

dirty case,

dirty contact,

dead man,

loophole.

Privately, the reading was cleaner:

a damaged local enemy had been put back into circulation.

That meant somebody still found Slim useful.

Makaila stood and came around the table.

"If he back," she said, "he ain't back the same."

"Exactly."

That was what the city didn't yet understand. Men like Slim did not come out of collapse clean. If he was back, then somebody bigger had decided he still had function left in him.

The city still thought local.

Barry was already thinking boardroom.

Chapter Five - Of Daniel and the Purchased Enemy

Slim first heard the deeper shape of his return through his lawyer.

That was fitting.

Daniel Lemsky was not the kind of man who wasted his own presence on a caged asset before the door was already opening. Men at that level don't step into the frame until the thing they want has been made usable in public again.

So the lawyer came.

Slim sat across from him in visitation looking older in the wrong places and younger in the weak ones. Prison had sanded some of the shine off him, but not the vanity.

"There's an opening," the lawyer said.

Slim tried to hold his face together. Hope lit behind his eyes anyway.

"What kind of opening?"

"Enough to move for an appeal bond."

Corrupt narcotics contact. Poisoned integrity. Chain weakness. Circumstances.

Slim heard some of it. The rest got swallowed by one larger thought:

out.

By the time the bond landed and the gate opened, he had already convinced himself that he had somehow earned the corridor.

The black car waiting outside was too refined to belong to any of his old people.

That was the first clue.

His lawyer was already inside. Slim got in, looked around the leather and quiet, and asked, "So who really behind this?"

The lawyer adjusted his sleeve.

"You're being given an opportunity. Don't waste it by asking the wrong question too early."

The ride ended at a room built for men who preferred systems over spectacle.

That was where Slim met Daniel Lemsky.

Daniel did not greet him like an equal.

Did not greet him like a rescued ally.

He greeted him like a returned instrument.

"You have been given an opportunity," Daniel said.

Slim nodded like he already understood it.

"Your appeal bond is the first opening, not the final victory. What comes after depends on your willingness to become useful."

Slim translated that word immediately into a language more flattering to himself.

Important.

Funded.

Feared again.

Visible again.

Daniel meant none of that first.

"Lemsky Universal is prepared to place you under the umbrella," Daniel said.

Slim sat straighter.

Now the appetite really woke up.

"You will have access to an annual operating budget of two hundred million dollars. Fifty million will be allocated against your catalog acquisition and repositioning. Your label can be revived. Your music can be scaled. Your visibility can be restored."

Slim was already gone.

Freedom.

Money.

Revenge.

Validation.

"There are terms," Daniel said.

Slim forced himself to look serious.

"Such as?"

"We control the flow and the narrative of your music. Certain styles from certain labels will be prioritized according to our marketing agenda. Distribution, release strategy, visibility, and placement all move through our structure. You will be funded, but not without direction."

Slim almost laughed.

Not because it was funny.

Because to him the trade was so obviously worth it that the chains barely sounded like chains.

"So let me get this straight," he said. "I'm out, I'm funded, and I get to run it back?"

Daniel did not blink.

"You get to return," he said. "Whether you run it correctly remains to be seen."

Slim grinned.

"Nigga, I'm down."

He signed.

That was all.

No wrestling with principle.

No concern over narrative control.

No question whether he was being purchased as a weapon.

Freedom, vanity, and funding had answered every moral question before conscience ever got a chair in the room.

After Slim was gone, Daniel's assistant asked, "And Barry Parker?"

Daniel turned toward the window.

"If he would not come under the structure," he said, "then the structure will come around him."

That was the real beginning of the next war.

Chapter Six - Of Benjamin, the Road, and the Uneasy Alliance

Benjamin Lemsky believed in fairness the way some men believed in engineering.

Not as sentiment.

As structure.

That was what Barry respected in him.

Plenty of powerful men liked to talk fairness when it cost them nothing. Benjamin was different. He had built Dignified Distribution with a seriousness that proved he understood the long money in roads, shelves, movement, and backend discipline.

He didn't need to rob creators blind.

He controlled the channel.

That made him fairer than his father.

It did not make him innocent.

The deal was active now. Heavens Gates kept one hundred percent of the royalties and one hundred percent ownership of the masters.

But Benjamin kept the road.

Every Heaven's Gates product moved through Dignified Distribution and through Dignified Distribution alone.

That meant stores.

Placement.

Inventory.

Returns.

Shelf life.

Rhythm.

One evening they sat in one of Benjamin's offices above a distribution floor humming with quiet machine life. Benjamin, dressed light and athletic as usual, slid shipment sheets across the desk.

"South Carolina still your deepest concentration," he said. "But the spillover cleaner than I expected."

Barry looked down at the numbers.

Cleaner was the right word.

Not one hot single.

Pattern.

Repeat movement.

Catalog behavior beginning to resemble discipline.

"That's because the base ain't fake," Barry said.

Benjamin nodded.

"That's why I signed you. Most people got records. You got architecture."

Barry took that in.

Not we.

You.

Good to know.

Benjamin leaned back.

"Just understand something. Sole distribution means sole distribution. I'm not trying to colonize your sound, but I don't build roads for people to half-use them."

Barry met his eyes.

"I understood that when I signed it."

Benjamin smiled slightly.

"Good. I'd hate to think I was doing business with a man who only hears the flattering parts of a deal."

Barry's own smile came slow and crooked.

"And I'd hate to think I was doing business with a man who thought owning the road made him author of the destination."

Benjamin laughed low.

That was why they could work.

Neither man needed the other to pretend.

But Barry was no fool. A road owned by another man is still a vulnerability, even when that man is more honorable than most. He would use the road. He would build through it. He would scale through it.

And somewhere in him, another thought had already started taking root:

one day, Heavens Gates would need roads of its own.

Chapter Seven - Of Freek Setter, Sarah Rae, and the Widening Spell

The first thing people noticed was the sound.

The second thing they noticed was the atmosphere around the sound.

By then Freek Setter had become more than just a producer in the room. He was part of the inner current of Heavens Gates, one of the men helping define what the movement felt like when it entered a speaker.

That mattered.

Because Daniel's side had already begun preparing noise - cheap aggression, flat records, loud posturing, and manufactured urgency meant to make destruction feel like motion. Against that, Barry needed more than talent. He needed atmosphere. He needed records that held spirit deeply enough that imitation would only expose the emptiness of whoever tried it.

Freek Setter gave him that.

So did Sarah Rae.

So did Gangsta.

And now another layer had formed around the work.

Gangsta and Sarah Rae were falling toward each other.

Not loudly.

Not foolishly.

Not in the kind of way that turns a room into gossip before it ever becomes something real.

Closer to how Barry and Makaila had moved that first year - always near, always inside one another's orbit, always standing close enough that other people could feel what was forming before the two inside it fully named it.

They had gotten like that.

She was around more. He was quieter around her. The looks lasted longer. The pauses meant more. Long sessions ended with them still near one another even after the room had emptied.

One late evening Freek Setter sat low at the board, hoodie loose on his shoulders, building a beat that sounded like somebody had laid velvet over danger. Gangsta leaned over the back of the engineer's chair. Sarah Rae sat with a notebook, long dark frame folded into the couch, curls falling down one side of her face.

Freek Setter played the loop.

Slow piano.

Low bass.

Something beautiful in it.

Something lying in it too.

Sarah Rae looked up first.

"That one feel dangerous."

Freek Setter did not turn.

"It is."

Gangsta smirked.

"Everything this nigga make feel like somebody beautiful lying to you."

That got a laugh out of Sarah Rae, warm and low enough that Gangsta ended up looking at her instead of the board for longer than he meant to.

She caught it.

He didn't look away immediately.

Neither did she.

Freek Setter noticed. Said nothing.

That was how the spell widened.

Chapter Eight - Of the Bigger Army

Makaila had not said we will have a bigger army for effect.

She had said it because she had already seen enough pattern to know that talent without protection becomes tribute, and systems without defensive capacity eventually get forced into surviving on somebody else's terms.

Barry understood that.

So the army grew.

Not in the childish sense.

Not reckless men with guns and no books.

A real army.

Capacity.

Intelligence.

Response.

The security company formalized first. What had once been trusted details and quiet relationships became hierarchy, standards, route planning, event mapping, artist transport, property coverage, contingency.

No crash-outs.

No men who confused intimidation with discipline.

The media arm came next. Makaila had been right there too. Heavens Gates could no longer rely on scattered freelancers and favors if a real image war was coming. Shooters, editors, archive keepers, rollout planners, designers - all of them tightened into a proper company.

Not just content.

Narrative control.

One long afternoon at Sunset, Makaila stood in the middle of three moving parts at once and looked more at home than anybody else in the building. One security lead waited on staffing assignments. A media coordinator needed sign-off on a camera expansion. One of the retail tenants wanted closing-time adjustments against event traffic.

Makaila handled it all without raising her voice.

Barry watched from the hall for a while before stepping in. She caught him and asked, "You standing there admiring me or auditing me?"

Barry let one side of his mouth tilt.

"Same thing sometimes."

He took the clipboard from her, scanned it, and handed it back.

"You was right."

She tilted her head.

"About?"

"The army."

She tucked the board under one arm.

"I know."

That was another reason they worked. Neither of them needed fake modesty to cover a clear win in vision.

Barry looked down the corridor where security, artists, media crews, and office people all moved in separate rhythms that somehow still belonged to the same body.

"Noise getting financed," he said. "Which mean confusion getting financed too."

Makaila nodded.

"And if confusion get funded long enough, people start mistaking chaos for power."

Barry touched her face briefly, grounded.

"Make it bigger."

Makaila's answer came calm and certain.

"Already am."

Chapter Nine - Of Affiliation Tested by Fire

It is easy to call yourself family when the rooms are full and the money is circulating.

Pressure tells the truth.

Heavens Gates had entered the season where truth begins sorting people faster than ambition does.

Barry had already tightened the affiliation structure. Each label head now functioned more clearly as an executive under the umbrella, with room to build under themselves but not without accountability to the larger body. At the time some heard that as growth. Some heard it as challenge. A few heard it as control.

Now came the testing.

A Charleston branch wanted looser release authority while still expecting full access to Heaven's Gates resources. A Florence affiliate had one young artist wobbling under machine-funded attention. An Orangeburg wing remained solid at the top but had one lieutenant carrying too much ego for a season that required law.

None of those fractures were catastrophic alone.

That was what made them dangerous.

Barry started calling people in.

One by one.

Small circles.

Short rooms.

Not to rant.

To read.

One evening at Sunset, he sat across from three affiliate heads in a closed room with no music, no crowd, and no energy to hide behind.

"You can't eat family food and act surprised when family law come with it," he said.

Nobody answered immediately.

Good.

The Charleston man nodded too fast. Barry marked it.

The Florence man looked down before meeting his eyes again. Barry marked that too.

The Orangeburg man just received the sentence. Barry respected him most for that.

"This thing too big for half-loyalty now," Barry said. "Too many people fed by it. Too many eyes on it. Too much in motion for anybody to be playing both ends because pressure finally arrived."

The Charleston head cleared his throat.

"Ain't nobody playing both ends."

Barry looked at him. Not hard. Not loud. Just long enough for the man to hear his own uncertainty.

"Then that sentence wasn't for you."

That shut him up.

Barry leaned back slightly, more relaxed than tense, which somehow made the authority heavier.

"If you under this umbrella," he said, "that means your strength belong to the body and the body strength belong to you. If that feel too close to ownership for your ego, then what you really want ain't family. It's free use."

That line landed.

Because every man in the room knew somebody it fit exactly.

Pressure was sorting them now.

That was the fire.

Chapter Ten - Of Drill, Infection, and the New Money

Barry never hated darkness in music.

He hated formatting.

The process by which chaos gets cleaned up just enough to become marketable and then pushed wide enough that boys in different cities begin mistaking imported destruction for authentic expression.

Now Columbia was getting touched harder by that infection.

Slim's return accelerated it.

Machine money moved behind weak local rappers who had neither Gangsta's weight nor Sarah Rae's spirit nor Freek Setter's atmosphere nor Asad's discipline. They had noise. Recklessness. Visibility hunger. And now, because certain lanes were being funded, that was enough.

Songs started naming real robberies.

Shootings appeared in bars like trophies.

Tracks functioned like open letters to enemies and invitations to retaliation.

The city was no longer just hearing violence.

It was being trained to circulate it.

One night after a smaller affiliate dispute nearly spilled ugly, Barry stood outside with Makaila in the humid dark while the event throbbed inside behind them.

"They learning the wrong lesson," he said.

Makaila lit her smoke.

"They seeing the money attached to the corpse," she said, "and not the machine behind it."

Barry nodded.

"Exactly."

Once destruction gets visibly funded, some young fools assume destruction itself is the opportunity. They don't see that the opportunity still belongs to the men financing the atmosphere.

That was the new money.

Poison with a budget.

Chapter Eleven - Of Smear, Features, and the Flood of Noise

The machine never attacks a thing like Heavens Gates only through opposition.

That would be too honest.

The smarter move was always flood.

Flood the field with enough noise, confusion, distraction, and counterfeit motion that the real thing has to spend half its energy proving it is still real. Put money behind weaker artists. Push records that don't need to last, only need to contaminate the atmosphere. Reward crash-outs with camera time. Turn disrespect into distribution.

That was the shape Daniel's answer began taking in the city.

Slim was the face of the re-entry. The real war wasn't just Slim. It was what moved behind him.

Certain names were suddenly getting features they had no business getting. Mediocre records had budgets. Young rappers with no audience beyond two blocks and a funeral home's worth of enemies were showing up in expensive videos sounding like they had been told destruction itself was a market lane.

Because they had.

One evening Asad came into Barry's office with three discs and a legal pad.

"What you got?" Barry asked.

"Three new projects from that side."

Barry looked at them.

"Worth hearing?"

Asad answered plain.

"Worth understanding."

Barry listened to all three.

When it was over, he tapped one finger once against the desk.

"They not building culture."

Asad nodded.

"They building infection."

That was the flood.

Not organic collaboration.

Strategic contamination.

The smear didn't always look like slander. Sometimes the smear was simply making so much filth visible that the public ear started losing the habit of distinguishing what was actually clean.

Barry understood that.

And he also understood Heavens Gates would not survive this phase by simply being better.

It would have to remain clearer.

Chapter Twelve - Of Gangsta, the Burden, and the Cost of Being Seen

The city had started needing too much from Gangsta.

That was the real weight of it.

Young boys saw survival in him.

Older women saw hope.

Men who had wasted years looked at him and imagined a version of themselves that might have made it if structure had found them early enough.

The streets still claimed him.

The people now claimed him too.

And somewhere inside all that, Leon Moyd still had to wake up every day and remain a person.

Sarah Rae saw it.

That was one reason he stayed so close to her. She was one of the few people around him who did not consume him through his symbolism first. She saw the burden before she saw the myth.

One night he sat on the edge of the Sunset stage while crews broke down around him. Sarah Rae stood below, tall and slim and dark in the low amber light, curls down, face quiet and reading.

"What you carrying?" she asked.

Gangsta looked down at the boards.

"Everybody."

She let that sit.

Then he said, "Them boys watching me. Them old ladies praying over me. Niggas looking at me like I'm proof something can turn. Streets still looking at me like I'm theirs too. Sometimes it feel like everybody got a version of me they need more than I get to just be me."

Sarah Rae stepped closer.

"That's because they do."

He looked at her.

That answer hit him harder than comfort would have.

She wasn't trying to soothe him. She was telling him the truth.

"That don't mean they right," she said. "It mean you seen."

Later, when he reached down from the stage and took her hand, it wasn't dramatic.

Just honest.

That was the cost of being seen.

The machine, eventually, would know that too.

Chapter Thirteen - Of Asad and the Hidden Center

The city saw the faces first.

That was natural.

It saw Gangsta.

It saw Sarah Rae.

It saw the shows, the records, the rumors, the pressure.

What it did not see - at least not correctly - was the hidden center holding the body together.

That center increasingly had Asad Jones all through it.

If Barry was still the deeper architect and Makaila the unseen financial spine, Asad had become something like the nervous system of the day-to-day operation. Quiet enough not to draw thirsty attention. Important enough that if he vanished the rooms would feel the absence before they could name all the places it touched.

He ran sessions.

Trained younger engineers.

Corrected lazy ears.

Fixed weak arrangements.

Set standards.

Moved talent through rooms without letting those rooms lose dignity.

One afternoon he stood in Studio B with a younger engineer trying too hard to sound advanced. The boy kept flattening a vocal under unnecessary polish because he thought professional meant removing all the human edge.

Asad let him fail long enough to hear himself.

Then said, "Take all that off."

The boy blinked.

"What?"

"All that you hiding behind."

The engineer frowned. "I'm cleaning it up."

"No," Asad said. "You scared of the rawness in it, so you trying to decorate it till it stop asking anything of you."

The room went still.

That was what made Asad different.

He corrected beyond technique.

He corrected the psychology under the technique.

Later Barry told him plain:

"The city see faces. The machine see leverage. But the hidden center? That decide whether pressure break a thing or sharpen it."

Asad understood.

He was not there to shine.

He was there to keep the engine honest.

In a war like this, that made him one of the most dangerous men in the building.

Chapter Fourteen - Of Alfred Wilson and the Men Who Build Cages

The room was too expensive to sound human.

Dark wood. Thick carpet. Leather. The kind of room where decisions could be made about thousands of lives without any of the men present having to smell what those decisions became on the street.

Alfred Wilson sat there like he belonged to a deeper tier of the room than the others.

Copper leathery skin.

Low white afro.

No wasted movement.

No anxiety.

He spoke over white power the way a man speaks over furniture he has already priced into the arrangement.

The meeting had been called around rising violence. Publicly the language would later be soft - concern, crisis, youth, intervention. Privately the room knew violence in the right volume became policy opportunity, contract opportunity, prison opportunity.

"They are going in the right direction," Alfred said.

The room quieted.

"In the future this will produce bigger profits and solidify our control amongst these peasants."

He did not smile.

That made it colder.

A younger politician asked, "So what exactly is the posture?"

Alfred looked at him like the question itself had revealed weakness.

"We feign disdain for the violence," he said. "Publicly, we mourn. Publicly, we request concern. Privately, we do nothing that would stop the pattern from feeding the channels we need filled."

He let that settle.

"In fact," he added, "we should be thinking ahead to more prison development now."

That was the appetite in the room.

Not the music.

Not the dead boys.

The future cages.

And somewhere inside all of it, music still mattered. Because music could help season the atmosphere. Help normalize death. Help prepare boys for cages before the first handcuff ever touched their wrists.

That was why Alfred did not dismiss the cultural side.

He respected its utility too much.

Chapter Fifteen - Of Blood Memory and the Shadow in Dreams

The dreams ain't come like no soft blessing.

They came like pressure with a pulse.

At first Barry brushed it off. Too much noise in the city. Too much pressure on the music, the labels, the young bloods, the money, the fake motion, the real danger. A man can explain away a lot when he still trying to keep one foot in plain logic and the other in what he know damn well he feel.

But these dreams was older than stress.

Older than thought.

Jimmy started showing up in them.

Not in no spooky white-sheet way. More like memory had found legs and decided to walk. Sometimes Jimmy looked old as dry wood and river stone, dark skin lined with years and eyes deep enough to make the dream itself feel like it was standing at attention. Other times he looked younger, shoulders straighter, less weather on his face, but the same weight in his gaze.

That's what bothered Barry.

Not fear.

Recognition.

One night he dreamed he was standing in a place that wasn't one place. A prison corridor and a dirt road and the back room of some old wooden church all at once. Cold and warm together. Tight and open together.

Jimmy stood ahead of him in plain clothes, still as judgment.

"You still think memory belong to the head," he said.

Barry frowned. "Where else it gon' belong?"

Jimmy's eyes held him still.

"In the blood. In the burden. In what move through you before language ever get permission to explain it."

Barry woke with sweat on his chest.

After that the dreams got bolder.

Sometimes Jimmy ain't say nothing. He'd just stand there at the edge of a field under a red-black sky, looking at Barry like a man waiting on another man to stop lying to himself. Sometimes there'd be

another figure deeper in the dream, too near to ignore and too far to claim.

Barry knew in that painful blood way who it was before he ever had proof enough to say it clean.

Solomon.

His father.

Or the shape of him.

Or the memory of him trying to cross through.

Always almost there.

Always not fully given.

One dawn Makaila found Barry sitting on the edge of the bed, elbows on his knees, bald head lowered, gray in his beard catching the first hard line of morning.

"Again?" she asked.

He nodded.

"You see him?"

Another nod.

She put her hand on the back of his neck.

"Who?"

"Jimmy."

That sat between them.

Then he said, "My daddy be near too. But never clear enough."

Makaila didn't rush to fix it.

"That mean the blood moving," she said.

Barry looked at her.

"What if I'm late to it?"

Her answer came low and sure.

"You ain't late. You just finally still enough to hear it."

The dreams kept coming.

And every time the city got louder, every time Slim's funded nonsense spread more poison through the music, every time the machine turned another young fool into a marketable casualty, the dreams got clearer.

This wasn't escape.

This was awakening with teeth.

The blood was remembering through him.

Chapter Sixteen - Of Jamila, the Crossing, and the First Signal

Barry was building more than a label.

More than a state circuit.

More than a business machine.

He was building bloodline too.

Dynasty.

Not the loud corny kind where men talk legacy but can't govern their own household. Barry meant it in the deeper sense. Structure passed through children. Order passed through pairing. Discipline passed through what and who you let get close enough to shape the next branch of your line.

Jamila was one of the clearest examples of that.

By Book Three she was eighteen or nineteen, only a little younger than Gangsta and Asad, already carrying herself with a seriousness people misread because of how soft she looked at first glance. Light caramel brown skin. Athletic build. A little tomboyish in movement. Soft natural curls that she could shape a hundred ways. Studious in the deeper way - not just grades, but systems. Financial systems. Administrative buildout. How companies held after applause left.

That was her lane.

And that was why the whole thing with Asad made sense so early.

It didn't begin with romance.

It began with study.

She had a school project for career day and decided she wanted to do her report on Asad's role as chief engineer for her father's studio operation. Part of it was simple - she thought it was cool. A young Black man only a couple years older than the crowd she was moving through already functioning as chief engineer and quiet builder in a real infrastructure.

But that wasn't all.

She was already drawn to order the way he was.

She noticed the clean way he moved.

How his clothes were always plain and right.

How he never looked hurried even when five things were happening.

How he corrected people without trying to humiliate them.

How he listened fully.

The first day she came to him with the folder, Asad was going over session notes in one of the smaller rooms at Sunset.

"My teacher said we got to do career day on somebody with a real job," she said.

"And you picked me?" he asked.

She shrugged.

"You the chief engineer for my daddy's studio."

One side of his mouth moved.

"That sound cooler in school than it do in here."

That got the first smile out of her.

From there she kept finding reasons to follow where Asad worked. Not silly. Not childish. She had found a rhythm in him she wanted to understand.

Makaila caught on before Barry said anything.

One afternoon she found Jamila pretending to organize papers while very obviously angling herself so she could still hear Asad in the next room explaining booking flow to a younger tech.

"You organizing them papers or listening through the wall?" Makaila asked.

Jamila looked up too quick.

"I'm doing both."

That answer was too honest to punish.

Barry saw soon enough too. But he didn't react in some overprotective father way. Didn't bristle. He was too strategic for that.

Instead he watched.

What he saw pleased him more than it troubled him.

Jamila didn't fling herself around Asad.

Asad didn't get loose around Jamila.

Everything between them was reserved.

That mattered.

Because Barry was building dynasty, not chaos.

And if Jamila was already naturally moving toward Asad - toward his steadiness, his discipline, his quiet centrality - then Barry had no need to force anything. Some pairings are stronger when they're

guarded instead of pushed.

One evening, after most of the building had thinned out, Barry stood at the far end of the hall watching Jamila ask Asad another question about session logs and booking structure. Asad answered seriously. He did not talk down to her because she was younger. He just answered her like she had the right to understand.

Makaila came up beside Barry, her locks brushing his arm.

"She's on him," she said.

"Yeah."

"He know?"

Barry smiled slow.

"He ain't stupid."

"You gone interfere?"

"Nah."

That answer held more than it first revealed.

He looked back down the hall.

Jamila stood with one hip turned slightly, curls tied back that day, notebook in hand, asking Asad something with full attention. Asad, clean and serious as ever, one hand resting on the table, answered with that same quiet thoroughness that had made Barry trust him in the first place.

"You don't force certain things," Barry said. "You just make sure foolishness don't get close enough to bend them off path."

That was the first signal in that line.

Not public.

Not named.

But real.

And sometimes real is all a bloodline needs at the beginning.

Chapter Seventeen - Of the Greeting and the Name in the Air

Every real thing gets named twice.

First in spirit.

Then in speech.

Heavens Gates had already been named in speech. That was Book One. The declaration. But what was moving under Book Three was older and stranger than the corporate face of a music confederation. It had not yet been fully named in public because naming a thing too early is one of the easiest ways to hand it over to enemies before it learns how to defend itself.

Still, it was in the air now.

You could hear it in the greeting.

The clasp.

The pause.

The look that lasted a beat too long to be casual.

One closed night at Sunset, after a private showcase that had run hotter and heavier than planned, the hall stayed half-lit while only insiders still moved through it.

Makaila came down the side aisle with her locks loose tonight, black ropes moving against the dark red line in her blouse, every step carrying that same country-bred authority she never had to announce. Barry stood near the stage edge in black, hands low, shoulders relaxed, copper skin taking on a darker sheen under the low lights, his gray beard making him look like somebody's executive and somebody's omen all at once.

Gangsta and Sarah Rae came in from stage left.

And there it was again.

Not just their closeness - though that too had gotten harder to miss. Gangsta's young hard face softened around her without losing danger. Sarah Rae, tall and dark and narrow-framed in all the right ways, carried old-soul beauty like it had chosen her body on purpose.

Asad moved up from the rear corridor with his same clean serious presence, clipboard in one hand, no wasted movement, and when he greeted Barry and then Gangsta and then Sarah Rae, the clasp, the pause, the look - all of it had deepened into something neither casual nor yet fully declared.

Makaila noticed it settle.

"It got a body now," she said.

"Almost," Barry answered.

That word mattered.

Almost.

Because Barry knew language could either shelter a thing or expose it too early.

Blood Frequency was already in the air.

Not as title first.

As condition.

As atmosphere.

As recognition.

One of the younger affiliate artists from Charleston stepped in wrong and tried to imitate the greeting too hard.

The room felt it instantly.

Barry cut one eye toward him and the young man's whole posture adjusted.

Makaila leaned toward Barry, her breath close enough to touch the side of his neck.

"The little ones already trying to wear it before they know what it cost."

Barry's answer came soft, almost amused, but with law under it.

"That's how you know it real."

By the end of the night nothing had been publicly announced.

And still, one truth had become impossible to ignore:

Blood Frequency was no longer just a thought.

It had become shared air.

And once air gets shared that deeply, war gets closer too.

Chapter Eighteen - Of Barry Parker and the Countermove

Barry never respected reaction.

Reaction was useful in a fistfight.

Maybe in a parking lot.

But in systems war? In cultural war? In the kind of old-money, new-noise conflict now pressing against Heavens Gates?

Reaction was a poor man's imagination of power.

A countermove was different.

A countermove did not just answer what was visible. It shifted the floor beneath the answer.

That was how Barry thought now.

He did not come out publicly talking tough. Didn't flood the city with rebuttal records. Didn't overexplain the machine's play to people who still got excited every time noise got a camera budget.

He moved the board.

Routes changed.

Schedules tightened.

Private meeting locations rotated.

Certain key people stopped moving on habits that could be studied.

Then quality got sharper.

If the machine was financing cheap blood and weak aggression, then Heavens Gates could not answer by merely staying good. Good wasn't enough. Better songs. Better mixes. Better curation. Better timing. No feeding the air with half-finished work.

One night in Studio A, Asad, Freek Setter, Sarah Rae, and Gangsta sat through a playback of three records that could have been released by most labels in the state without hurting the catalog too much.

Barry listened to all three.

Then said, "None of them say enough."

Silence.

That was another thing about him. The older he got, the more dangerous his calm became. More easy-going on the surface, more sly around the edges, but the standards sharper because he no longer needed to perform seriousness for anybody to feel the law in him.

Gangsta leaned back.

"They hard though."

Barry looked at him.

"So is plenty things that don't need releasing."

That ended it.

Then commerce got sharper.

Sunset became more than venue and retail corridor. It became measurement. Which acts were really drawing? Which labels were actually building audience? Which spaces had real rhythm and which ones only looked busy off adjacency?

And finally trust got narrower.

Not everybody under the umbrella needed the same information. Not everybody deserved the same depth of access. Barry sorted more ruthlessly now between people who loved power and people built to carry it.

One late night the upper office at Sunset looked less like music business and more like a war room. Maps. Files. distribution reports. Security notes. Route adjustments. Retail observations. Smear patterns. Quiet names circled in blue and black.

Makaila sat there with her locks pulled back, one gold hoop catching the lamp light, face sharp and fully in command. Barry sat across from her in black, sleeves rolled, bald head low over the page, gray in his beard deepening every thoughtful shadow in his face.

"They trying to bait quick response," she said.

"I know."

"They think if they flood hard enough, you'll eventually answer like the street."

That pulled a smile out of him.

"That's because they still don't know the difference between me and where I come from."

"And what is it?"

"Where I come from taught me pressure," Barry said. "But pressure ain't the same as purpose."

There it was.

The law.

The stain had taught him pressure.

Prison taught him pressure.

Detroit taught him pressure.

The city taught him pressure.

The machine was teaching pressure now too.

Purpose had come slower.

That was why Barry Parker was still standing while so many other men who understood nothing but pressure had already turned themselves into cautionary tales.

"No," he said when Makaila told him that was why he was still ahead. "That's why we still ahead."

That was the real countermove.

A system still intact enough to think higher than the conflict.

He went to the window and looked down into the lot.

"Let them get bigger," he said.

"You sure?" Makaila asked.

Barry's answer came easy, almost light, which somehow made it colder.

"Yeah. I want to see the full size of the hand before I cut at it."

That was Barry at his most himself.

Serious, yes.

But not stiff.

Not clenched.

There was trickster in him there. Old slyness. Crossroad intelligence. The black-and-red smile under the sentence. A man so calm in the face of pressure it almost looked like he was flirting with destiny.

Chapter Nineteen - Of Proof Against the Machine

The machine had money.

That was never the question.

It had reach too. Budgets. narratives. labels. boardrooms. bought faces. dirty corridors. distributors with blood on one hand and spreadsheets on the other. It had enough juice to put cameras on fools, enough power to make weak songs seem important for a season, enough appetite to turn young Black death into a market lane and then call the whole thing culture.

What it did not have - not in Columbia, not yet - was proof stronger than Barry's.

That became clear in the numbers first.

Not loud.

Not sexy.

The real kind.

Benjamin saw it before almost anybody else outside the core did. He was in one of his offices, dressed light like he usually did, one hand on a report while his analyst walked him through movement across regions.

The screen showed what the machine had paid to make look dominant - spikes of noise, bursts of traffic, cheap attention tied to thinner product. But below all that, or maybe deeper than it, another shape kept holding.

Heavens Gates.

Not exploding.

Not disappearing.

Holding.

Catalog moving.

New product moving.

Show attendance converting.

Affiliate labels holding.

Retail rotation surviving past the hot week.

Cities outside Columbia still buying in.

Benjamin sat back.

"That's the difference," he said.

"Between what and what?" the analyst asked.

He tapped the page.

"Between a funded event and a living system."

That was the proof.

The machine had struck. It had pushed crash-outs, funded noise, blown smoke around cheap artists who could barely hold a record together if the money got quiet for two weeks.

And still, Heavens Gates was there.

Still breathing.

Still feeding.

Still drawing.

Still converting labor into livelihood.

Still moving like something built for weather instead of applause.

Sunset proved it too.

The hall off Sunset wasn't just packed on obvious nights anymore. The life around it had gotten thicker. The retail spots were rotating money. The showcase circuit had become a path for regional acts. The merch tables stayed working. The media arm had real demand. The security arm had contracts. The small side businesses - food vendors, printers, stylists, seamstresses, duplication boys - all had enough steady motion tied into Heavens Gates that the place had become what Barry always meant it to become:

a local economy with a pulse.

One evening Barry walked through Sunset slow, not because he was tired, but because he liked to see what the body was doing when it didn't know the head was watching.

He saw one of the younger designers loading merch mockups into a box.

He saw a security lead checking rear access with that same quiet boredom disciplined men have.

He saw Sarah Rae crossing the hall in a close-fitted dark green top and black jeans, tall and slim and dark as polished earth, her long frame moving with that same ancestral grace that always made a room feel older when she passed through it.

He saw Gangsta down near the floor seats with two younger artists, talking low, not at them but into them.

He saw Jamila near the office wing with a stack of papers, curls tied back that day, athletic shoulders straight, looking like young woman and future administrator at once.

This was the proof.

Not one star.

A body.

Makaila found him near the side corridor where the hall opened into the retail run. Her locks were up that night, piled and pinned, neck long, face sharp, numbers in one hand.

"They hit us hard," she said.

Barry nodded.

"And?"

Makaila glanced down at the figures, then back at him.

"And we still standing where they thought we'd be staggering."

Barry smiled the smallest smile.

"They ain't understand what they was looking at."

"No," Makaila said. "They thought it was music. It's blood in this one."

That line hung there.

Because it was true in more ways than even she fully knew.

The machine had come with money and counterfeit movement.

Heavens Gates answered with order and continuity.

And continuity, in the long run, humiliates hype.

Chapter Twenty - Of Open War

By the time the season turned, nobody honest could pretend anymore.

The war was open now.

Not because somebody held a press conference.

Not because the city had suddenly grown wise enough to explain the deeper architecture cleanly.

Open in the real sense.

Everybody could feel it.

The artists felt it.

The labels felt it.

The streets felt it.

The businesses felt it.

The politicians felt it without naming it.

The boardrooms felt it through sales reports and regional complaints.

The prison men felt it through projections and public fear.

The young boys felt it because they no longer knew whether to imitate the funded chaos or submit themselves to the harder law of structure.

Slim helped make it visible.

He had been out long enough to start wearing his return the wrong way - too loud in some rooms, too confident in others, flashing the new backing without fully understanding that real machine power is usually quieter than the men it purchases. But that was Slim's nature. He couldn't help but brag by posture even when his mouth stayed mostly shut.

One night, in a lounge full of local opportunists, side-label nobodies, and just enough cameras to make stupidity feel historic, Slim finally said it plain.

He was coming for Barry.

And for Gangsta.

By morning the city had translated the statement into what it really was:

a declaration.

That reached Barry before breakfast.

He was already up, already dressed in black, going over route notes while the first clean line of morning slid across the table. Makaila stepped in with the message, her locks bouncing once against her shoulders as she crossed the room with purpose, black mug in one hand, folded notes in the other.

"He said it."

Barry looked up.

"How?"

"Like a man who finally think borrowed money made him taller."

That pulled a low sound out of Barry that wasn't quite a laugh.

Makaila set the notes down.

"He named you. Named Gangsta. Enough witnesses around it that by tonight the whole city gone hear one version or another."

Barry read the paper.

His face didn't tighten.

That was the thing about him now. The older Barry got, the more dangerous his calm became. He was serious, yes, but not stiff with it. There was too much old slyness in him now, too much almost-playful coldness when the enemy finally made the mistake of announcing themselves before understanding the board.

"He had to," Barry said.

Makaila leaned one hip against the table.

"Why?"

"Because he can't afford mystery no more. Only theater."

That was true.

Slim had no system deep enough to wage the kind of war Daniel's money was trying to fund through him. All he had was declaration, aggression, symbolism, and that same old need to look bigger than his own spiritual smallness.

Gangsta heard next.

He took it harder than Barry, not because he was less disciplined now, but because his history with Slim sat in more personal soil. He stood in one of the rear rooms at Sunset, black tee on, shoulders tight, young face hard in that way it got when old violence tried to pull him backward.

"He say he coming for me?" Gangsta asked.

Barry stood across from him and let the question breathe.

"He say he coming for what you mean."

That hit deeper.

Because Gangsta was no longer just a body in this story. Slim and the machine hated him more now for what he represented than for what he had done. A transformed young Black man under structure is a more dangerous symbol than a wild one in most wars.

Sarah Rae was there too.

Tall by the door, curls down that evening, dark skin catching the low amber light like it had warmth under it even in silence. She said nothing at first, but her eyes stayed fixed on Gangsta with that same grave softness she carried whenever she sensed the burden in him rising faster than his words.

Gangsta caught the look.

And some of the heat left his shoulders.

Asad entered a few moments later and the room changed shape again. Tall, steady, clean, carrying that same quiet athletic calm and serious face that made confusion lose some of its nerve the minute he arrived.

"So it's open now," he said.

Barry nodded.

"Yeah."

Nobody moved for a second.

Then Asad asked the real question.

"What that change?"

Barry looked at all three of them.

"Nothing in principle. Everything in posture."

That was the difference between old street minds and real systems. A public threat might change how you move. It should not change who you are.

Still, the city beyond that room had already started choosing sides more openly.

Some boys drifted toward funded noise because they thought chaos was where the money lived.

Some artists leaned harder into Heavens Gates because they finally understood structure only matters once it gets tested.

Some businesses got quieter around both camps, not wanting to be seen too close to either until survival itself picked a lane.

The elite watched.

The boardrooms watched.

Benjamin watched.

Daniel watched hardest.

Alfred Wilson's kind watched too, because once conflict ripens enough, cages start smelling profitable from farther away.

That was why Book Three had to end here.

Not with closure.

With clarity.

The war was open.

The city knew it.

The industry knew it.

The machine had stopped pretending it was only observing.

And the bloodline inside Barry had begun remembering strongly enough that he could no longer mistake this for merely a label dispute or a local grudge wearing expensive clothes.

It was deeper than that.

Music and prisons.

Fathers and sons.

Roads and blood.

Cities and spirits.

Noise and law.

Counterfeit movement and real inheritance.

All of it had met in one season.

That night, long after the halls emptied and even Sunset felt like it had finally exhaled, Barry stood alone on the upper level near the back glass overlooking the dark lot. His black shirt disappeared into the room except where light touched the curve of his head, the red at the cuff, the silver in his beard. He looked like a man standing between worlds and not asking permission from either one.

Below, the building slept lightly.

Not peacefully.

Ready.

Barry rested one hand on the glass and looked out into a city that had birthed him, sharpened him, wounded him, fed him, tried him, and now once again demanded he answer it at a higher level.

Behind his eyes the dream roads waited.

Jimmy's silence waited.

Solomon's shadow waited.

Makaila's numbers waited.

Gangsta's burden waited.

Jamila's crossing waited.

Asad's rooms waited.

Sarah Rae's voice waited.

The blood was moving.

The machine was moving.

The city was moving.

And now there would be no more confusion about the season they had entered.

Open war.

Barry's mouth moved into the smallest half-smile, that same sly little edge that always made him look like he had already stepped around fear before it finished arriving.

Then he said to the dark, low and sure:

"Aight."

That was all.

But in Barry Parker's mouth, it sounded like a door opening and a verdict at the same time.

Thus ended Blood Frequency, being Book Three of the Heavens Gates Chronicles.